them towards goals. Whatever the political benefits he gained from the riots, it seemed as if he was always anxious to rewrite his record, reinvent his personality, his tasks made even more urgent by the desire to forget and even obliterate events which paradoxically and fundamentally shaped his political persona.

His bureaucrats were given twin tasks—implement schemes that would deliver tangible benefits to the people in the shortest possible time, and ensure the chief minister's persona as a development-oriented leader gets totally identified with the successful projects. In this period, the Gujarat government launched multiple projects, from those aimed at girl child education to tribal area development to irrigation and drinking water schemes. The aim was clear—show Gujarat as a state committed to governance and its leader as a *vikas purush* (man of development).

A good example of the extent to which Modi was willing to go to push the '*bijli, sadak, shiksha aur pani*' (electricity, roads, education and water) agenda was his Jyotigram Yojana, designed to ensure twenty-four-hour power supply, especially to rural Gujarat. A flat rate, approximating to market costs, was to be charged. Farmers who refused to pay would be penalized while power theft would lead to jail. RSS-backed farmer unions protested; the Opposition stalled the assembly. Unmindful of the protests, Modi went ahead with the scheme, convinced of its long-term benefits. 'Only someone with Modi's vision could have pulled off Jyotigram,' says one of his bureaucrat admirers. The Gujarat Model was born and would pay rich dividends to its leader in the years ahead. Today, Gujarat's power supply compares favourably with other states as does a double-digit agricultural growth rate. And even if there are dark zones as reflected in troubling child malnutrition figures, the overarching impression is of a state on the fast track to prosperity.

But the Gujarat Model was not just about growth rates and rapid development. It was also about recasting the image of the man who was leading Gujarat. It was almost as though development was Modi's shield against his critics who still saw him through the prism of the riots. For example, Modi took great pride in his Kanya Kelavani (girl child education)